

see the emotion on a player's face, the tears of DR Congo players, the celebrations of Lionel Messi and Erling Haaland and the tension that might otherwise be lost in the scale of the venue.

Just as important, Charlotte says, is the invisible infrastructure that allows fans to experience the event the way modern audiences expect to. When Messi scored the goal against Austria that took him past Miroslav Klose as the World Cup's all-time leading scorer, supporters sent "25.9 terabytes of data" from the stadium in roughly two hours — enough, she notes, "to stream high-definition video for a year."

Fans no longer come only to watch; they come to share, post, record and prove they were there.

"The greatest thing about watching the game on television is wishing you were there," Charlotte says. "When you get to be there, the ability to share that with others is important." A modern stadium, in her view, must be built for that reality too.

But Charlotte is careful about how she talks about technology and AI.

"You can get too much data," she says. "Data for data's sake. But there is great data that can affect and

make you change certain things that make that experience and that connection more valuable to that person who suggested it, and thereby to all, and that's the sweet spot." The point, in her view, is not simply to collect information but to listen well enough to act on it.

"You've got to listen. You've got to bring them in. You've got to invite them to the table. Make them feel involved in the book. Make them feel involved, because you want them to celebrate when something big happens, and if you want them to feel that, then you need that connection."

That same logic eventually pushed the Cowboys beyond the stadium itself. If a team only touches its supporters on matchday, Charlotte argues, it is leaving too much of the relationship to chance. The organisation had to become physically present in people's lives in other ways as well. That instinct led to The Star in Frisco, the Cowboys' headquarters and mixed-use development north of Dallas, which Charlotte sees as the physical embodiment of what the franchise wants to be beyond Sundays.

That challenge was even starker because, as Charlotte points out, most Cowboys supporters never actually enter the stadium. "Only seven per cent of our fans ever go into the stadium," she says. "Even though we can hold 90,000 people, that does not touch the surface of how many fans we have." If the Cowboys were to mean something to the other 93 per cent, they

needed more than ten home dates and a giant stadium. They needed a year-round home that could bring supporters into the franchise's orbit even when no game was being played.

"Sometimes you need the bricks and mortar of something to make an idea and a cultural affinity real," she says. "It's like having a mosque. It's like having a church. You can have a faith, but you need the bricks and mortar of something to ground you in it."

The Cowboys wanted that kind of home beyond matchday. So, they moved their practice base to Frisco, partnered with the local school district and built an indoor football stadium that also serves as the team's practice facility. It hosts high-school football, graduations and other community events. Students come through the organisation for internships and placements. Around it has grown a district of restaurants, hotels, retail, entertainment and training spaces. It is not simply where the Cowboys work. It is where the Cowboys exist in public. "We wanted to be the centre of the community," Charlotte says. "We needed to not just patronise it. It needed to be authentic. How many touchpoints could we create in the community where people already were, where they valued something, and we could tie into that?"

That idea of community has also



Killer blow: Spain's Mikel Merino celebrates his matchwinner against Portugal in the Round of 16 match at the Dallas stadium. AFP